

## A VISUAL NOVEL SCRIPT SAMPLE

# The Metamorphosis

Morning at the Door

*An original branching adaptation inspired by the opening premise of Franz Kafka's novella; not a quotation from any published English translation.*

COMMON

Scene 1 - The Awakening

## Scene 1 - The Awakening

**Narrator:** *Before sunrise had fully loosened the darkness, Gregor Samsa woke beneath his familiar blanket and found that his body no longer belonged to the life he remembered.*

**Gregor:** Why is the ceiling so far away?

**Narrator:** *A hard shell pressed against the mattress. Too many thin legs moved above him, each answering a different command - or no command at all.*

**Gregor:** I have become an insect. Stop. All of you, stop.

**Narrator:** *The legs continued their nervous dance.*

**Gregor:** This must be a fever. I will close my eyes, count to ten, and wake up properly.

**Narrator:** *He counted twice. Nothing changed.*

**Gregor:** The first train has already gone.

**Narrator:** *Rain scratched softly at the window. His alarm clock ticked with the calm cruelty of an office supervisor.*

**Grete:** Gregor? Are you awake?

**Gregor:** Yes. I am getting ready.

**Narrator:** *The answer sounded clear inside his head. Beyond the door, his sister heard only a strained, brittle noise.*

**Grete:** Are you ill?

**Gregor:** No. Please do not come in.

**Mother:** Gregor, the office sent someone. They say you missed the early train.

**Gregor:** Someone is here already?

**Father:** Open the door. You have kept us waiting long enough.

**Chief Clerk:** Mr. Samsa, your absence has caused considerable concern. Your recent performance has not escaped notice.

**Gregor:** Give me five minutes. I can explain everything.

**Chief Clerk:** I am afraid your words are quite impossible to understand.

**Narrator:** *Gregor tried to sit upright. His new body rocked once, twice, then fell back against the bed with a hollow thud.*

**Mother:** What was that?

**Gregor:** Nothing! I dropped something.

**Grete:** Gregor, please let me see you.

**Narrator:** *The key waited in the lock. If he could reach it, there would be no more hiding.*

**Gregor:** If I stay here, they will imagine something worse. If I go out, they will see the truth.

*Decision point: What should Gregor do?*

CHOICE

Go Out or Stay Inside

## Go Out or Stay Inside

A

**GO OUT**

Unlock the bedroom door and face the family.

B

**STAY INSIDE**

Keep the door locked and hide the transformation.

PATH A

Go Out

## Go Out

**Narrator:** *Gregor lowered himself from the bed. He landed badly, but the carpet softened the blow.*

**Gregor:** One movement at a time.

**Narrator:** *He crossed the room by pushing with one side of his body and pulling with the other. At the door, he raised himself against the wood and caught the key between his jaws.*

**Grete:** Did you hear that? He is turning the lock.

**Mother:** Thank heaven.

**Father:** At last.

**Narrator:** *The key turned. Gregor pulled the door open just wide enough for his armored head to pass through.*

**Mother:** Gregor?

**Narrator:** *His mother's hands rose to her face. The Chief Clerk stepped backward. Gregor's father did not move at all.*

**Gregor:** Please remain calm. I can still work.

**Chief Clerk:** Keep that creature away from me!

**Gregor:** It is me. I only need time to dress.

**Grete:** Gregor... can you understand us?

**Narrator:** *Gregor moved farther into the doorway. The Chief Clerk abandoned his hat and hurried toward the stairs.*

**Chief Clerk:** The company will hear of this!

**Father:** Back into your room.

**Gregor:** Father, let me explain.

**Father:** Back!

**Narrator:** *His father lifted his walking stick, not striking, but leaving no doubt about the direction Gregor must take.*

**Mother:** Do not hurt him!

**Grete:** Gregor, please. Go back for now.

**Narrator:** *Gregor looked at his sister. She was afraid, yet she had not run.*

**Gregor:** I am sorry.

**Narrator:** *He retreated. The door closed between them, and the key turned from the outside.*

**ROUTE LINK: CONTINUE TO THE MESSAGE**

## PATH B

## Stay Inside

## Stay Inside

**Narrator:** *Gregor moved away from the door and pulled the blanket over his unfamiliar body.*

**Gregor:** No. Not yet.

**Father:** Gregor, open this door immediately.

**Gregor:** I cannot.

**Chief Clerk:** Refusal will be treated as a deliberate breach of duty.

**Gregor:** Tell the manager I am sick.

**Chief Clerk:** Your voice suggests something beyond an ordinary illness.

**Mother:** Then we should call a doctor.

**Father:** We should call a locksmith.

**Narrator:** *Gregor pressed his body against the lower half of the door, as if his weight could protect the room from every possible visitor.*

**Grete:** Everyone, please stop. Shouting will not help him.

**Chief Clerk:** Miss Samsa, your brother has placed the company in an unacceptable position. If he will not appear, I have nothing further to discuss.

**Gregor:** Wait. I will come tomorrow.

**Chief Clerk:** Your employment may not survive until tomorrow.

**Narrator:** *The Chief Clerk's footsteps crossed the hall and descended the stairs. The apartment door slammed behind him.*

**Father:** You have ruined us.

**Mother:** He may be seriously ill.

**Father:** Then why does he refuse to let us help?

**Gregor:** Because you would be afraid of me.

**Narrator:** *No one understood the words.*

**Grete:** Gregor, I will leave water outside. When everyone has calmed down, perhaps you can open the door.

**Father:** He has until noon.

**Narrator:** *The family withdrew. Gregor listened as their voices became whispers and their whispers became silence.*

**Gregor:** They do not know what I am.

**Narrator:** *He looked toward the key.*

**Gregor:** Perhaps it is better than knowing.

**ROUTE LINK: CONTINUE TO THE MESSAGE**

## CONVERGENCE

## The Message

## The Message

**Narrator:** Near noon, soft footsteps returned to the hallway.

**Grete:** Gregor, it is only me.

**Narrator:** Something thin slid beneath the door: a sheet of paper and a short piece of charcoal.

**Grete:** Your voice has changed. But perhaps your mind has not.

**Grete:** If you understand me, tap the floor once.

**Narrator:** Gregor lifted one of his smaller legs. He hesitated, then struck the floor.

**Sound:** Tap.

**Grete:** Once means yes.

**Grete:** I knew you were still there.

**Grete:** Can you write?

**Narrator:** Gregor pushed the charcoal with the edge of one leg. It rolled away. He tried again, trapping it between two pointed limbs.

**Narrator:** Gregor dragged the charcoal across the paper. Letter by letter, he formed a single word.

**Gregor:** Help.

**Grete:** Slide it back to me.

**Narrator:** He pushed the paper beneath the door.

**Father:** Grete, what are you doing? Step away from there.

**Narrator:** Grete picked up the message. For several seconds, she said nothing.

**Grete:** He wrote to me.

**Mother:** Gregor wrote something?

**Narrator:** A shadow covered the narrow strip of light beneath the door.

**Father:** Ask whether the thing inside that room is truly my son.

**Narrator:** Gregor held perfectly still.

**Grete:** Gregor... if you are still Gregor Samsa, tap once.

**Narrator:** He raised one leg.

**Sound:** Tap.

**Narrator:** From the far side of the door came another tap in reply.

**Sound:** Tap.

**Gregor:** Grete?

**Narrator:** Grete had not moved.

END OF SAMPLE - TO BE CONTINUED